

EYEWITNESS 1862–65

Journey to Freedom

In the early stages of the Civil War, enslaved people living in the Confederacy who escaped to the Union side were known as contraband. Thousands worked for the Union cause, receiving a small wage; others took over the plantations they had once worked on.

“In the summer of 1862, freedmen began to flock into Washington from Maryland and Virginia. They came with a great hope in their hearts, and with all their worldly goods on their backs. Fresh from the bonds of slavery, fresh from the benighted regions of the plantation, they came to the Capital looking for liberty, and many of them not knowing it when they found it. Many good friends reached forth kind hands, but the North is not warm and impulsive. For one kind word spoken, two harsh ones were uttered; there was something repelling in the atmosphere, and the bright joyous dreams of freedom to the slave faded—were sadly altered, in the presence of that stern, practical mother, reality.”

ELIZABETH HOBBS KECKLEY (1808–1907), FORMER SLAVE WHO BECAME A SUCCESSFUL SEAMSTRESS IN WASHINGTON, D.C., FROM HER MEMOIR *BEHIND THE SCENES*, 1868

“The way we can best take care of ourselves is to have land, and turn it and till it by our own labor—that is, by the labor of the women and children and old men; and we can soon maintain ourselves and have something to spare. And to assist the Government, the young men should enlist in the service of the Government, and serve in such manner as they may be wanted . . . We want to be placed on land until we are able to buy it and make it our own.”

REVEREND GARRISON FRAZIER AT A MEETING OF BLACK AMERICAN MINISTERS AND CHURCH OFFICERS WITH EDWIN M. STANTON, SECRETARY OF WAR, AND MAJOR GENERAL WILLIAM T. SHERMAN IN SAVANNAH, GEORGIA, JANUARY 12, 1865